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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Excessive overtime at IDHS detailed

Agency also facing increased allegations of staff misconduct

By **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

Illinois Department of Human Services employees have worked excessive overtime — with one worker more than tripling their annual salary of \$66,000 — which could have an adverse effect on people in the department's care, a state audit released earlier this month found.

The Dec. 4 report from Illinois Auditor General Frank Mautino's office, which covered fiscal years 2021 through 2023, also found that misconduct allegations within IDHS have increased and that the department's inspector general's office has been slower to investigate complaints.

The report lays out the latest problems for an agency still dealing with fallout from accusations that a downstate mental health center repeatedly covered up staff misconduct amid allegations of abuse and neglect of residents.

The report noted that due to a high number of allegations, it's likely that many of the same issues documented at Choate Mental Health and Developmental Center in Anna exist at other centers.

The overtime issues detailed in the report are eye-opening. In fiscal year 2023, IDHS reported that 70% of the more than 7,200 employees at its state-operated facilities had overtime that accumulated a total of 1,606,962 hours. Of those, 330 employees tallied more than 1,000 hours in OT, the audit found.

A worker with an annual pay rate of \$66,000 logged 3,331 hours in overtime during the fiscal year and collected \$227,800 in gross pay during the calendar year, the audit found. Another employee tallied 2,745 of the extra

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Missile suspected in crash

Airliner downed over Kazakhstan likely result of Russian air defenses, aviation experts claim

Associated Press

Aviation experts said Thursday that Russian air defense fire was likely responsible for the Azerbaijan plane crash the day before that killed 38 people and left all 29 survivors injured.

Azerbaijan Airlines' Embraer 190 was en route from Azerbaijan's capital, Baku, to the Russian

city of Grozny in the North Caucasus on Wednesday when it was diverted for reasons still unclear and crashed while making an attempt to land in Aktau in Kazakhstan after flying east across the Caspian Sea.

The plane went down about 2 miles from Aktau. Cellphone footage circulating online appeared to show the aircraft making a steep

descent before smashing into the ground and exploding in a fireball.

Other footage showed part of its fuselage ripped away from the wings and the rest of the aircraft lying upside down in the grass.

Azerbaijan mourned the crash victims with national flags at half-staff across the country Thursday. Traffic stopped at noon, and signals sounded from ships and trains as it observed a nationwide moment of silence.

Speaking at a news conference Wednesday, Azerbaijani Presi-

dent Ilham Aliyev said it was too soon to speculate on the reasons behind the crash, but the weather had forced the plane to change from its planned course.

"The information provided to me is that the plane changed its course between Baku and Grozny due to worsening weather conditions and headed to Aktau airport, where it crashed upon landing," he said.

Russia's civil aviation authority,

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TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Seven principles, one sound

Windy City Ramblers brass band members Frank J. Morrison, left, and Phil Fornett play percussion as band leader Mario Abney dances during a Kwanzaa celebration at Malcolm X College in Chicago on Thursday. Kwanzaa, created by activist and scholar Maulana Ron Karenga in 1966, is based on African harvest festival traditions from West, East and Southeast Africa. The word Kwanzaa comes from a Swahili phrase, "matunda ya kwanza," which means "first fruits," referring to a harvest period. Celebrations run from Dec. 26 to Jan. 1, with each day dedicated to a principle — for example, Dec. 26 is devoted to Umoja, which means unity.

Security demands foil plans for towers

Fate of endangered State Street buildings still hangs in balance

By **Brian J. Rogal**
Chicago Tribune

Historic preservationists thought their demands had been answered this summer when the federal government appeared to green-light the rehab of the two century-old office towers it's owned on State Street for nearly two decades. But security restrictions governing how the buildings are used going forward have raised questions about the future of the structures.

The groups had fought for years to save the Century and Consumers buildings at 202 and 220 S. State St., both rare surviving examples of the Chicago



The Consumers Building, left, at 220 S. State Street, and the Century Building, at 202 S. State Street. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE 2023

School of Architecture that had been at risk of demolition.

Preservationists say the buildings might be successfully redeveloped as apartments, affordable housing or a hotel, bringing life back to a long-dead section of State Street.

But the U.S. General Services Administration, which manages the properties, has placed security protocols and restrictions on the buildings that could bar those uses.

Preservationists worry the protocols, which are in response to security concerns raised by

judges and other employees at the nearby Dirksen U.S. Courthouse, could pave the way for the government to raze the buildings after all.

"Since the beginning they have had these security requirements that pretty much make it impossible to do any redevelopment," said Michael Edwards, CEO of the Chicago Loop Alliance. "The unfortunate part is GSA has owned these buildings, which are critically important to State Street, for years and left

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Lake Michigan waves a clean power source?

Remote spots like Beaver Island could benefit from research backed by \$3.5M federal grant

By **Karina Atkins**
Chicago Tribune

A single underwater cable supplies Beaver Island with its power.

Storms, which are becoming increasingly frequent and severe with climate change, have knocked out the lights for days. A maritime accident once cut electricity for months on the 600-person island 30 miles off the coast of western Michigan.

What if the water surrounding Beaver Island could be the key to delivering the small island with more reliable — and clean — power?

Backed by a \$3.5 million grant from the National Science Foundation, researchers at the University of Michigan are working with island residents to explore converting wave energy into electricity. If they're successful,

naturally occurring waves would make the remote community more resilient to climate change and mitigate climate change-fueling carbon emissions.

Remote islands with compromised grid reliability are early candidates for nascent wave energy converters. Once the technology is established and costs drop, the renewable power source is expected to complement solar and wind power in urban coastal communities as well, said Vishnu Vijayasankar, a doctoral candidate leading the university's efforts.

Vicky Fingeroot, a Detroit native, began traveling to Beaver Island in 2006.

"I never thought about energy or how we got it when I bought my first piece of property here back then," she said.

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INSIDE Dylan goes electric in solid biopic

A Hollywood love letter to Bob Dylan, "A Complete Unknown" doesn't exactly challenge any mythology around the Minnesota-born folk star, but it works well on its chosen, extremely glossy terms. **Review in A+E**

